emancipatory ideas and some traditional norms? Is that kind of feminism not feminism at all?

In some ways, the BJP's ideas on woman power draws from what is globally referred to as the 'third wave' of feminism. The 'first wave' in the mid-nineteenth and early twentieth century focused on getting equal rights for women. In India, the Constitution wrote equal rights for women into law in 1947, long before many developed countries did, though the social position of Indian women did not change for decades.[160] 'Second-wave' feminism from the 1960s and 1970s saw discrimination against women as the outcome of cultural, political and religious inequality and focused on issues of identity. It argued that women had to get out of these bonds to be truly free. A product of the American Cultural Revolution of the 1960s, it was epitomised by the slogan 'The Personal is Political' that became synonymous with the women's liberation movement. The 'third wave' from the 1990s challenged the 'second wave' and emerged as a backlash against it. Broadly stacked under the rubric of 'post feminism', its adherents largely 'agreed with the goals of feminism, but did not identify themselves as feminists'. Unlike 'second-wave' activists, the 'third wave' rejected the idea that women are independent islands and argued that they could be both independent and have familial or cultural roles.[161]

The BJP's women's outreach arguably drew from this way of thinking but added a Hindu twist to it. Modi often uses religious imagery to portray women, for example. During Durga Puja celebrations in October 2020, he announced that women of India should be respected like the goddess herself.[162] He also published a collection of poems titled *Letters to Mother*, which conflated the nation with the universal idea of motherhood.[163] Despite the BJP's success in mobilising women, most gender-based critiques of Hindu right-wing movements have failed to grapple with its nuances, much like the widespread mainstream academic reluctance to engage with gender and spirituality as a subject meriting serious study. The Pakistani scholar Ayesha Jalal has argued that women and spirituality did not receive enough attention because academic theology had relegated it to the margins of intellectual discourse. 'The feminist movement for the most part too has skirted around it